

II

THE NATURE AND ORIGIN OF "FIRST ESDRAS"

I. THE TWO RECENSIONS OF THE EZRA HISTORY

In the case of several of the books of the Old Testament, the Greek Bible gives us a text which differs widely from the traditional Hebrew or Aramaic. In Jeremiah there has been an extensive transposition of chapters, so that in the second half of the book the order in the Hebrew is altogether unlike that in the Greek. Which, if either, of the two represents the original order is still a matter of controversy. In Esther the Greek contains a number of rather long passages which are wanting in our Hebrew and are probably secondary, even if possibly translated from a Hebrew original. Moreover, the history of the tradition of the text is often a very complicated one. In several cases the Greek exists in two or more rival versions or recensions, as in the Books of Tobit and Judith. In the case of Daniel we have three different traditions. The oldest Greek version departs widely from our Hebrew-Aramaic text, not only in adding or subtracting brief passages here and there, but also in including the separate stories of Susanna and Bel and the Dragon. The later Greek Bible effected a sort of compromise by adopting Theodotion's translation of our massoretic Hebrew and yet retaining the added stories.

Now in the latter part of the Chronicler's history of Israel, in the section dealing with the return from the exile, the rebuilding of the temple, and the work of Ezra, almost exactly the same thing has happened as in the case of Daniel. The old Greek translation, with its transpositions, its one long interpolation, and its other minor peculiarities, was in strong disagreement with the Hebrew text which was preferred in Palestine in the second century A. D., and which soon came to hold the field as the only authoritative form of the narrative. Accordingly, a later translation, based on this massoretic Hebrew, was put into circulation in place of the older version, and soon supplanted it in every region where the Greek Bible was in use. There seems to be good reason to believe that this later translation was the work of Theodotion, whose version thus, in the case of the book Chronicles-Ezra-Nehemiah,

occupies a place in our modern Greek Old Testament precisely similar to that which it occupies in the case of Daniel. The discussion of this question will be reserved for another place. At all events, the old version was so effectually superseded that it very narrowly missed being lost altogether; in this fact, again, furnishing a close parallel to the history of the Daniel text.

There is to be noticed, at the outset, one important point in which the case of the rival recensions of the Ezra story differs from the other cases with which it has just been compared. In Jeremiah the transpositions, though extensive, were comparatively harmless. They brought about no serious contradiction or improbability. In Daniel and Esther the additions, though extensive, were not such as to interfere in the least with the principal narrative. They were simply joined on externally, and exercised no influence on their surroundings. But the two recensions of the narrative dealing with the restoration of the Jews and the work of Ezra could not stand thus peaceably side by side, for the one gives the lie to the other. As for the transpositions, they are effected in the middle of a connected history, with dates, successive kings, and a necessary order of events. It makes comparatively little difference whether Jer. 31 comes before or after Jer. 41, or even whether in I Kings, chap. 20 precedes or follows chap. 21; but it makes all the difference in the world whether the train of exiles described in Ezra, chap. 2, received permission to return from Cyrus or from Darius. And as for the one addition, the Story of the Three Youths, the proverbial bull in the china shop could not do more thorough and more vociferous damage. Every adjacent portion of the history is either stood on its head or else reduced to fragments.

Yet the tradition of the Greek church, with one voice, names this troublesome fragment "*First Esdras*," while the version which faithfully renders our massoretic text is only given second place. Josephus, as is well known, believed its version of the post-exilic history to be the correct one, and so, doubtless, did the most of his contemporaries, even in orthodox Jewish circles.

II. PAST AND PRESENT THEORIES REGARDING THE "APOCRYPHAL" BOOK

"First Esdras," or "Third Ezra," or "The Apocryphal Ezra," or "The Greek Ezra," as it has been variously called, has had an interesting history. There is probably no one of all The Old

Testament writings which has been so inadequately studied, and which is so seriously misunderstood among Old Testament scholars at present. St. Jerome put the tremendous weight of his authority against it (in his Preface to Ezra and Nehemiah: *Nec quemquam moveat quod unus a nobis liber editus est, nec apocryphorum tertii et quarti somniis delectetur; quia et apud Hebraeos Esdrae Nehemiaeque sermones in unum volumen coarctantur, et quae non habentur apud illos, nec de viginti quatuor senibus sunt, procul abjicienda*), and his word was law, as usual, for the Latin church from the Middle Ages onward, and exercised a profound influence over the whole western world. The book was excluded from the Complutensian Polyglot (1514-17), and was not even admitted by the Council of Trent (1546);¹ in printed editions of the Vulgate it is given place in an appendix at the end of the Bible, after the New Testament. By modern scholars generally this "apocryphal book" is not regarded as a survival from the old Greek version of this portion of the Old Testament, nor even as the part of a recension which once included all of Ezra and Nehemiah; on the contrary, it is believed to be a later free compilation made with a "tendency." That is, just as the Chronicler, in his day, edited and expanded certain parts of the history of Israel into a book which should inculcate his own views, so (according to the generally accepted theory) a later and unknown writer selected that part of the history which "began" with Josiah's passover (as though this were a natural beginning!) and ended with the career of Ezra, and rewrote it, with certain significant changes and additions, according to his own purpose.

This view is altogether mistaken, but it is the only one which has any recognition at the present time. All of the modern textbooks of Introduction, commentaries, and encyclopaedia articles, whether English, German, or French, speak of the "author" of First Esdras, and of his probable "purpose" in making this com-

¹ It is singular that the belief should have had such wide currency, at this time, that First Esdras *did not exist in Greek*. Thus Lupton, in his Introduction to First Esdras (*Speaker's Commentary*), p. 5, quotes the remark prefixed to the Latin version of the book in the noted Latin Bible edited and published by Stephanus at Paris in 1557: "*Hujus libri ne Graecum quidem codicem, nedum Hebraeum nemini (quod sciam) videre contigit.*" The form of the quotation which I give is that of the original, of which I have a copy. Lupton is mistaken, however, in supposing that this note is to be attributed to the scholar Vatablus (whose name is used in an unwarranted way by the editor of this Bible); nor can it have come from Claudius Badwell, who did indeed prepare the translation of the Apocrypha for this Bible (see LeLong-Masch, *Bibl. Sacra*, II, p. 480), but only of the books which stood in the Complutensian Polyglot. The remark is to be attributed to Stephanus himself or to one of his unnamed helpers.

pilation. The question is even seriously discussed whether this "author" (1) made up his book from our canonical Greek version of Chronicles-Ezra-Nehemiah; or (2) made use of an independent Greek version; or (3) made his own translation from the Hebrew-Aramaic original. That he made his "compilation" in Greek is taken for granted, since it is the general belief that the interpolated Story of the Three Youths, as we have it, is not a translation from a Semitic original. It is a fact that speaks volumes for the general neglect of the book, that Schürer in both the first and second editions of his *Geschichte* maintained the view that First Esdras was compiled from our canonical Greek Old Testament—though any well-equipped university student could demonstrate the contrary to a certainty by an afternoon's work on any chapter in the book.

To illustrate a little further the current view, and the treatment now given to this "apocryphon" by Old Testament scholars: The DeWette-Schrader *Einleitung* (8th ed., 1869, p. 565) bravely confessed inability to recognize the purpose of the "author" of First Esdras in compiling it, remarking: "Ein Zweck dieser characterlosen Compilation lässt sich nicht entdecken;" but the great majority are content to repeat over, each from his fellow, Bertholdt's naïve hypothesis that the writer intended to provide a history of the temple from the latter part of the regal period down to the time when the cultus had been restored. Kusters, in his *Wiederherstellung Israels in der persischen Periode* (German trans. by Basedow, pp. 124-26), unfolded a much more elaborate theory—with even less support from the document itself. Of course, the abrupt ending of the "book" (in the middle of a sentence!) has been generally noticed, though few have made any attempt to explain it. Ewald's conjecture, that the work was left unfinished by "its author," is frequently repeated, e. g., by Strack, *Einleitung*⁴, p. 152 ("Das Buch, welches von seinem Verfasser nicht vollendet worden zu sein scheint," etc.), and by Guthe, in Kautzsch's *Apokryphen des A. T.*, p. 2. In most textbooks of Introduction to the Old Testament First Esdras is ignored—as though it stood in no close relation to the Old Testament!—and this, too, even by those who profess to believe that it represents a Hebrew-Aramaic text differing in many respects from our massoretic recension. In Cornill's *Einleitung*⁵, for example, it receives not a syllable of mention. In Driver's

Introduction it is given a brief note at the end of the chapter on Ezra and Nehemiah. By commentators the two "books," Ezra and First Esdras, are usually kept entirely separate. If the commentaries on Chronicles and on Ezra-Nehemiah mention First Esdras at all, it is only as a *curiosum*. Bertholet, in his commentary on Ezra and Nehemiah (in Marti's *Kurzer Hand-Commentar*), does, indeed, devote a section to the Greek Ezra in his introduction, pp. xvi, xvii, but his statements regarding it are notably confused and ill-digested, while in the commentary itself he makes no serious attempt to use it. In general, his attitude toward the apocryphon is characteristic of a certain irresponsible method of dealing with sources which is far too prevalent in modern Old Testament criticism: any comparison of the Greek Esdras text, in occasional difficult passages, is a work of supererogation, of which the commentator may boast; the idea that he is in duty bound to consult it *all the time*, and to make a really critical study of it does not suggest itself.

The commentaries on First Esdras, again, have not brought us far toward an understanding of its origin and true character; as might be expected from the fact that all the commentators have believed the book to be simply a late and "historically worthless" compilation. The parallel portions of the canonical books are only occasionally consulted, and then in the most perfunctory way. In the *Kurzgefasstes exegetisches Handbuch zu den Apokryphen des A. T.*, by Fritzsche-Grimm—the one thoroughgoing and scholarly commentary on the Old Testament Apocrypha, but now long outgrown—the treatment of First Esdras (by Fritzsche) is below the level of the rest; chiefly, no doubt, for the reason already given. No commentary on the book that has appeared since that date (1851) is worthy of serious attention. Lupton, in Wace's *Speaker's Commentary* (1888), is very superficial; and both he and Zöckler (1891) are equal to the feat of subjecting the book to a fresh study without even finding out that it offers us a separate, extra-canonical translation from the Semitic! In the critical examination of text and versions next to nothing has been done, though this is a most promising field for investigation. The statements as to these things which now and then appear are for the most part either false or inaccurate. Fritzsche (*Comm.*, p. 9) asserted that the best text of First Esdras is to be found in the uncial B and the cursives 52 and 55, and this most misleading

statement has been industriously copied by his successors, no one taking the trouble to test the matter. In the second edition of Cornill's *Einleitung*, p. 268, one could even read that Jerome(!) was the author of the Vulgate version of our apocryphon. Nestle (*Marginalien und Materialien*, p. 29, n. 2) says that "the Lucian recension" (meaning the text printed in Lagarde's *Librorum vet. test. canonicorum pars prior graece*) furnished the basis of the Syriac translation; a theory which would seem plausible for the first nine verses of the first chapter, but from that point on is seen to be absolutely false. There has not even been made a careful comparison of the two Greek versions, the canonical and the apocryphal, as they stand in our printed Greek Bibles, to say nothing of inquiries as to their nature, history, and mutual relations. Even for the restoration of the massoretic Hebrew text of Chronicles-Ezra-Nehemiah, no critical use of even the current Greek text of First Esdras has ever been made. A few (most recently Guthe, in the *Polychrome Bible*) have included "The Greek Ezra" in their apparatus in a more or less haphazard and superficial way, but such attempts as these can have no considerable value.

The one scholar who in recent times has defended the view that First Esdras represents a Greek translation which is older than the one contained in the corresponding books of our canonical Greek Bible is Sir Henry Howorth, who has argued the case more than once,² with much learning and acumen. This view had been held, in one form or another, by not a few scholars; among them Grotius, in his annotations, 1644; Whiston, *Essay towards Restoring the True Text of the Old Testament*, 1722; Pohlmann, "Ueber das Ansehen des apokr. iii. Buchs Esras," *Tübing. theol. Quartalschrift*, 1859, pp. 257-75; Ewald, *Gesch. des Volkes Israel*, IV, 1864, p. 166; and Lagarde, *Psalterium Hieronymi*, 1874, p. 162, note. No one of these scholars, however, set forth the view so fully and vigorously as Howorth, nor do they seem to have appreciated, as he has, the great importance of this conclusion. Nevertheless, the proof which Howorth has been able to bring forward is by no means conclusive; the skeptic would not

²In the *Academy*, 1893, January 7 and 21, February 4 and 25, April 15, June 17, July 22; in the *Transactions* of the Ninth International Congress of Orientalists at London, Vol. II (1893), pp. 69-85; and (most fully, and including the substance of all the previous articles) in the *Proceedings of the Society of Biblical Archaeology*, May, 1901, pp. 147-59, November, 1901, pp. 305-30, June, 1902, pp. 147-72, and November, 1902, pp. 332-56.

be compelled by it. He does, indeed, show with a formidable array of evidence that the canonical recension of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh. *might well be* much later than the First Esdras recension, but he fails to show that it *is* in fact later. His assumption (*Proceedings Soc. Bib. Arch.*, May, 1901, p. 151), that any Greek translation which closely follows the text of our present Hebrew Bible must be derived from Aquila, Symmachus, or Theodotion, will hardly be accepted by those who have carefully studied the Greek Old Testament. He assumes, in like manner, that the canonical Greek version of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh. is the work of Theodotion—as Grotius, Whiston, and Pohlmann had conjectured before him—but without being able to bring forward any shred of evidence in favor of this opinion, beyond the fact that Theodotion's version of Daniel has found a place in our Greek Bible. The one prime necessity—if the current beliefs as to the Ezra books are to be superseded—is a well-grounded and plausible theory of the origin and mutual relations of the two recensions now existing. Such a theory has never been formulated,³ and Howorth has failed to provide one. His main conclusions, touching these matters, are the following: (1) First Esdras gives us the original form of this history; that is, (a) the *order* in our apocryphon (Ezr. 4: 7-24 following Ezr. 1: 11, and Neh. 7: 73-8: 12 following Ezr. 10: 44) is the primary and correct one; and (b) the Story of the Three Youths formed a part of the history as it was compiled by its author. (Howorth makes no attempt to prove that our Greek text of the story is a translation from the Semitic, though this proof—which has never been supplied—is essential to his theory.) (2) Origen, or perhaps "his editors," made our First Esdras by cutting a piece out of the middle of the "Septuagint"⁴ version of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh., and then editing and correcting it to some extent. (3) Our canonical Ezra-Nehemiah is the result of a thoroughgoing and arbitrary re-arrangement of the text, undertaken by the Jewish rabbis, who (a) knew nothing of Darius (II) Nothus, and (b) wished to identify Zerubbabel

³ The theory which is set forth in the following pages was presented in full at the meeting of the American Oriental Society at Andover, Mass., in April, 1896, but was not printed.

⁴ I suppose that Howorth means by "the Septuagint" that Greek translation of Chron.-Ezr.-Neh. which was the first to gain wide currency. I do not understand him to imply the belief that all—or even most—of the books of the Old Testament were translated at the same time, or by the same persons, or in any official or uniform way. Would it not be better, in the interest of clearness and accuracy, to cease altogether from using the term "Septuagint" in scientific treatise?

with Sanabassar, and (c) had various prejudices which led them to make deliberate and extensive alterations in the story of Nehemiah. These conclusions each and all present such serious difficulties that, in my opinion, even the view now generally held, with all its absurdities, would be likely to maintain its ground in the face of them.

III. THE NATURE OF FIRST ESDRAS

The main facts regarding the true character of our "apocryphal" Ezra book may be stated briefly as follows: *It is simply a piece taken without change out of the middle of a faithful Greek translation of the Chronicler's History of Israel in the form which was generally recognized as authentic in the last century B. C. This was not, however, the original form of the History, but one which had undergone several important changes.*

As is well known, the apocryphal book and the canonical book are, in the main, merely duplicate versions. But probably many fail to realize how close the duplication is. First Esdras contains a long passage, including chaps. 3, 4, and the first six verses of chap. 5, which is not found in the canonical recension. Aside from this, however, its material contents are exactly those of the corresponding parts of Ezra-Nehemiah. Beginning with the last two chapters of II Chronicles, it then includes the whole of the book of Ezra, and continues with a portion of the Ezra narrative⁵ which is now in our book of Nehemiah, namely, Neh. 8:1-12 and the beginning of the first clause of verse 13, where the fragment ends. In every part of all this history the two recensions generally agree with each other sentence for sentence and clause for clause. In the cases where they fail to agree the differences are due to the usual accidents of manuscript transmission, or to mistakes made by the one or the other translator. The universally accepted view, that First Esdras is a free translation, or a free working-over ("freie Bearbeitung") of the material, is mistaken. The translation is close, and the text as a whole has not been "edited," nor freely handled.

In investigating First Esdras, then, the all-important point of approach is the Story of the Three Youths, which at present stands only in this recension. We need a satisfactory theory of its origin

⁵As I have shown elsewhere, the passage Neh. 7:70-8:18 originally formed a part of the Chronicler's story of Ezra (following Ezra 8), and was accidentally transposed to the place where it now stands. See my *Composition and Historical Value of Ezra-Nehemiah*, pp. 29-34. I shall return to this subject later.

and history, and especially to know who incorporated it in this narrative, whether the Chronicler or some later hand. And this necessarily involves the further question, whether the original language of this episode—or, rather, the language in which it stood at the time when it was incorporated—was Semitic or Greek. If it never existed in Semitic form, then it certainly never was inserted by the Chronicler in his own book, nor could it ever have formed a part of any Semitic recension of these narratives of the Jewish exiles. On the other hand, if it can plausibly be maintained that the Greek text of the story, as we have it, is a translation from the Hebrew or Aramaic, then we have at hand the solution of some of the chief problems in this literary tangle.

It is fortunately possible to decide at once the question as to the Chronicler, while holding the question of the original language still in abeyance. The form of this history contained in I Esdr., chaps. 2-5, cannot possibly have been the form given it by its author. So scholars of all times have agreed, with hardly a dissenting voice, and for reasons that are conclusive. In the first place, the Artaxerxes correspondence, 2:15-25 (= Ezra 4:6-24), is palpably misplaced here. It constitutes, to be sure, a very good introduction to the Story of the Three Youths, which immediately follows, but forms in no sense the continuation of 2:1-14, where the narrative is obviously cut short in the middle. Again, the Story of the Youths is itself a disturbing element, and the disturbance this time is far more serious. The presence of this story inevitably turns the whole history upside down, bringing in contradictions and absurdities from which there is no escape. To mention only a single point: The events narrated in 5:46-70 [47-73] (notice verses 53 [55], 68 [71], and 70 [73]!) *are events of the reign of Cyrus*, even in this recension! There is no way of making them anything else, or of supposing that they were ever written in any other way. It is not easy to believe that any compiler of a serious history could make such an outrageous blunder as this. What is more, the episode of the Youths cannot be made to fit in anywhere else. Whoever tests the matter will speedily find that there is no point, before, in, or after Ezra 1-6, at which this episode is a possibility; at that, too, even if the name of the king be changed from "Darius" to some other name. Removed to any other place, it causes even greater disturbance than it makes at present.

Obviously, the story was not written for any such context as this; and it is equally obvious that the writer of this context had no thought of fitting it to contain the episode. The conclusion is certain, that the Story of the Three Youths is an interpolation, not a part of the history as it was originally composed. In view of the manifest traces of the Chronicler's hand in the extra-canonical verses just following the episode and serving to connect it with the canonical narrative (see below), the question might seem for a moment to be a legitimate one, whether the Chronicler himself may not have made the insertion, as an after-thought. But no one who gives the matter serious consideration will continue to entertain this hypothesis. The Chronicler is a writer of very considerable skill, who composed this history with a definite purpose, of which he never lost sight. He is most methodical in his literary habits, and we know him to be one who incorporated documentary sources in the way best suited to his own ends. He had himself carefully composed this most important narrative of the return (so essential to his pet theory!), writing it out, with vivid detail, in his own words (as scholars agree). It is not reasonable to suppose that he could have undone his own work and have given the lie to his own history in so stupid a manner, by squeezing in this unnecessary episode in an impossible place.⁶ It was not by the Chronicler, then, but by a later hand, that the story was interpolated.

The important question now arises, whether the interpolation was made in the original Hebrew-Aramaic text of the history, or in the Greek translation. It is characteristic of the general neglect which First Esdras has suffered, that no one has recently undertaken to determine, by examining the evidence, in what language the Story of the Three Youths was originally written. It is generally taken for granted that the language was Greek, and one scholar after another asserts this with confidence. Fritzsche (*Handbuch*, p. 6) wrote: "Ein hebräisches Original lag nicht zu Grunde, die Sprache verräth sich durchaus als ursprünglich hellenistisch; nur der Schluss, 5:1-6, macht eine Ausnahme, und von diesem besitzen wir das Original nicht mehr." This

⁶ If the story had been generally believed in his day, he would have known it when he composed his history. If it was not generally believed, he was under no necessity of inserting it. From our knowledge of the Chronicler, we should not expect the story to interest him especially. And finally, if he had wished to insert it in his completed book, he might easily have prepared a suitable place for it.

opinion has been adopted, as usual, by Fritzsche's successors; thus Schürer, Reuss, König, Zöckler, Lupton, Cornill ("ohne Zweifel griechisch geschrieben"), Guthe ("sicher griechisch"), Bertholet, and many others. Most of these, it should be noted, make an exception of the passage 5:1-6, which (like Fritzsche) they believe to have been translated from a Hebrew original. Howorth asserts that the story was written in a "Semitic" language (of course, his theory of the book requires this), but does not attempt to go farther. Ball, in his notes in *The Variorum Apocrypha* (1892), suggested one or two hebraisms in these chapters, but did not thereby make a Semitic original seem probable. Renan (*Hist. du peuple d'Israel*, IV, p. 180, note) said, in speaking of I Esdr., chaps. 3 and 4: "The original was certainly Hebrew."

As for the Greek in which I Esdr. 3:1-5:6 now stands, those who believe it to be more idiomatic than the ordinary "translation Greek" of the Old Testament are mistaken. It stands, in this regard, on exactly the same plane as the old Greek version of Daniel, or that of the books of the Kings, or of First Maccabees. From the beginning to the end, it shows an unbroken succession of Semitic idioms, reproduced with a faithfulness which is often very clumsy, and in several cases giving plain evidence of mis-translation. It is true that the subject-matter (namely, in the section 3:18-4:32) is unlike anything else in the Old Testament; and it is this fact, unquestionably, which misled Fritzsche into making his extraordinary remark about the language of the document. But if any student of the Greek Bible will look closely at the idiom of these two chapters, he will find it precisely the same which elsewhere results from a close rendering of a Hebrew or Aramaic original. Again, though as regards subject-matter and mode of treatment the section just named happens to stand alone in our Old Testament literature, it is by no means true that it has a "Hellenistic" sound. All those who are familiar with Semitic modes of thought and literary forms will recognize here a characteristic Semitic product.

The fact must not be overlooked, that the first six verses of chap. 5 are almost universally pronounced a translation from a Semitic original, as above noted. The fact usually *is* overlooked. Those who make the exception straightway forget it, and certainly never attempt to explain it. On what theory can this translated

"fragment" be accounted for? At present it plays a very important part in helping to connect the Story of the Youths with the Hebrew narrative 5: 7 ff. (=Ezra 2: 1 ff.). Its points of affinity with either section are obvious, and certainly not accidental. It sounds as though it were of one piece with the verses which immediately follow it, as well as with those which immediately precede it; and as for the Three Youths, there is an express allusion to them (somewhat parenthetical, to be sure) in vs. 6. But what end this passage of six verses may have served when connected with neither portion of its present context, no one, so far as I know, has ever ventured to guess. Of course, if the Episode of the Youths were originally written in Greek, it would follow that these six verses must have belonged to an entirely separate document. As for the following narrative (the Chronicler's), if this passage (5: 1-6) originally formed a part of it, how has it disappeared from our canonical book? And if it did not originally belong to it, how in the world can it have been detached from its proper surroundings and brought to this place? Guthe's amazing suggestion (Kautzsch's *Apokryphen*, p. 2) that it was composed by "the redactor" (!) certainly needs no refutation. The passage bears no resemblance whatever to an editorial patch. Nor is any theory of an isolated fragment plausible. We are not driven to any such strait as this, that we should be obliged to postulate a lost narrative of a return of Jews from Babylonia, written in Hebrew and translated into Greek, and now surviving only in these six verses! There is a far simpler hypothesis. Just as soon as it is observed that the Greek of this passage is the result of translation, it becomes probable that the Story of the Youths was incorporated in a Semitic form.

There is still other important evidence of this nature pointing to the same conclusion. The latter part of chap. 4 cannot so easily be separated from the first part of chap. 5. There is no perceptible break, nor anything to make it probable that two separate documents are joined at this point. The two concluding verses of chap. 4 cannot have formed the end of a piece of narrative. The closing words of verse 63, "and they feasted *seven days*," make it plain that their author intended to narrate what took place after the seven days. And in like manner the first words of 5:1, "*After this* there were chosen," etc., presuppose the words which just precede them. The two parts agree per-

fectly, and any attempt to pull them apart has the presumption strongly against it. Two documents were united, beyond doubt, somewhere in this vicinity, but it was not at *this* point. And again, the evidence of translation from a Semitic original is quite as noticeable in the latter part of chap. 4 as it is in 5: 1-6. Observe, for example, the idiom in vs. 63: *καὶ τὸ ἱερὸν οὐ ὠνομάσθη τὸ ὄνομα αὐτοῦ ἐπ' αὐτῷ*; and similarly in vs. 54: *ἐν τίνι λατρεύουσιν ἐν αὐτῇ*. Now although these verses do not belong to the unexpanded Story of the Three Youths (which, as will be shown presently, ends at 4: 42), they belong to the context in which it was imbedded. Moreover, in some of the verses which now form a part of the Story, and can only have been written in continuation of it, the marks which indicate the work of a translator are plainly to be seen. The verses 4: 44-46, 57, for example, in the sustained awkwardness with which they render Semitic idioms—and probably reproduce Semitic blunders—could easily be paralleled in other specimens of “translation Greek,” but hardly in Greek of any other type.

The antecedent probability, from every side, of a Semitic original for the Episode is thus overwhelming, and we may fairly take for granted, at the outset, the fact of translation (substituting “ohne Zweifel semitisch” for “ohne Zweifel griechisch”). Only very strong evidence in the Greek text of 3: 1-4: 42, such evidence, namely, as to show that it could not have been the work of a translator, could suffice to shake this probability; and such evidence, as has already been said, is not to be had.

It only remains to determine whether the original language was Hebrew or Aramaic. This question, usually a very difficult one, is here rendered easy of answer by the use of the Greek word *τότε*, in 3: 4, 8; 4: 33, 41, 42, 43, 47, which points plainly to an Aramaic original. The only places in the Greek Old Testament in which *τότε*, “then,” “thereupon,” is consistently used to continue a narrative are the Aramaic portions of Daniel and Ezra and this Story of the Three Youths. The usage is neither Greek nor Hebrew; the word can stand only for the Aramaic אָדָּן (or באַדָּן). It is not a question of one or two occurrences, such as can be found here and there in all Greek literature; the word appears again and again, all through the narrative, in every one of these sections in which the Greek is translated from Aramaic, but does not appear similarly anywhere else. In this Story there

is very little narrative, the space being occupied with discourses, letters and decrees, and the like; but wherever the story is resumed (notice especially 4: 41-47) we are pretty sure to see sentences and paragraphs headed by *τότε*.

Among the other marks of translation, the following are noteworthy:

3:3. *καὶ ἔξυπνος ἐγένετο* is quite impossible. The king is (and must be, for the sake of the story) sound asleep until vs. 13; cf. vss. 8 and 9! Those who were "waking" were the three men⁷ who constituted his body-guard. The original text may have read in some such way as this: *וּמִתְעִירֵן הָיוּ בְּאֶדְנֵן תְּלָתָה עַל־מִנִּיָּא*, "Thereupon the three youths bestirred themselves" (or "stood on guard"). The change would then have been very easy, since *בְּאֶדְנֵן* almost invariably (but not always; see Dan. 7: 11) begins the sentence.

3:5. *ἐνα λόγον*. The customary use of *ἓν* in the place of an indefinite article. So also 4:18.

3:5. *ὃς ὑπερισχύσει* is a sure mistranslation. It should be *τί ὑπερισχύει*, "what thing is the strongest," see vss. 10-12. The Aramaic probably had *מָה יִשְׁחָזֵק*.

3:12. *ὑπὲρ δὲ πάντα νικᾷ ἡ ἀλήθεια*. The *ὑπέρ* is impossible in Greek, as commentators have remarked (see especially Fritzsche). It is simply the translation of *עַל*, with which the verb *הִתְנַצַּח* is regularly construed; cf. Dan. 6:4.

4:14. *πολλοί* is an obvious (and quite natural) mistranslation of *רַב־בָּיִת*. The meaning in the original was "men are *mighty*," not "men are *numerous*," cf. vs. 2.

4:15, 16. The translator has here given us a false rendering and an incorrect division of clauses. Instead of our meaningless text, we must put a comma after *βασιλεύα*, and then read: *καὶ πᾶς ὁ λαὸς ὃς κυριεύει τῆς θαλάσσης καὶ τῆς γῆς ἐξ αὐτῶν ἐγένετο*. Cf. again vs. 2. The mistranslation is one of a very common type.

4:17. Is it possible that we have here a double rendering? Some such word as *הִדְרָא*, or *שְׁבִיחָא*, for example, would account for both *στολάς* and *δόξαν*, the one translation being literal and the other interpretative. The *στολαί* are not needed here. Compare the uses of the Hebrew words *הִדְרָא*, *צִבִּי*, and *תְּפִאֲרָתוֹ*, and the (mistranslated) verse I Macc. 14:9.

⁷ Ordinarily called "pages" because of the misunderstanding of this verse.

4:31. *καὶ πρὸς τούτοις*. Probably for *וְעַם דִּנְהָ*, which should here have been translated "and *in spite of* this."

4:37. *καὶ οὐκ ἔστιν* should probably be *εἰ οὐκ ἔστιν*. The original may well have been *וְלֹא אִתִּי בְּהֶוֶן קוֹשָׁטָא*; all men and all their works are evil, "if truth be not in them;" or the initial letter of *הֵן*, "if," may have fallen out accidentally after the last letter of the preceding word (*τοιαῦτα* = *דְּנָה* or *אֱלֵה*).

4:39. *τὰ δίκαια ποιεῖ ἀπὸ πάντων τῶν ἀδίκων καὶ πονηρῶν*. The *ἀπὸ* is a monstrosity here; see the commentaries. The Lagarde text, *δίκαια ποιεῖ, καὶ ἀπὸ πάντων τῶν ἀδίκων καὶ πονηρῶν ἀπέχεται*, is arbitrarily corrected, as the evidence of manuscripts and versions shows conclusively. Fritzsche thinks it likely that some Hebrew idiom "schwebte dem Verfasser vor," but confesses his inability to find an example of it in our Hebrew Bible. We have precisely this idiom in biblical Aramaic, in Ezra 7:26. The original text here was therefore undoubtedly *לְהֵן דִּינָא עֲבַד מִן כְּלָהֶן בִּישָׁא וְרִשְׁיָא*; Truth is no respecter of persons, "but executes judgment upon all evil and wicked men." The Latin and Syriac versions render correctly.

These examples will suffice. The Story of the Three Youths was written in Aramaic, and was inserted by a redactor in the Hebrew-Aramaic text of the Chronicler's history.

The process of combining the two narratives necessarily involved some harmonistic labors on the part of the redactor. The Story, in its original form, does not seem to have made any mention of the Jews. As far as 4:42—where it may well have ended—it contains not a word to give it connection with Jewish history or interests, with the exception of the single parenthetical clause in vs. 11, *οὗτός ἐστιν Ζοροβαβέλ* (*הוּא זְרַבבֶּל*), which has been universally recognized as an addition by a later hand. It may well be that this very brief, but very potent, gloss antedates the expanded form of the Story, and in fact was the ultimate cause of its inclusion in a history of the Jewish people; but, be that as it may, it is pretty certain that the expansion itself, through which the Story was made into a tale of exiles returning to Jerusalem by royal decree, was the work of the self-same redactor who interpolated it in the Chronicler's book.

Now it must be remembered that the Chronicler himself is giving, at this very point, an account of a return of exiles from Babylonia; and, what is more, that the leaders of his expedition

are Jeshua and Zerubbabel. The last portion of his narrative preceding the interpolated matter is 2:1-14 (= Ezra, chap. 1). In this he had told of the proclamation of King Cyrus, and how the Jews prepared to obey it; then, further, how the king brought out the sacred vessels belonging to the temple in Jerusalem (which are fully described and numbered), and delivered them into the hand of a Jewish prince named Sheshbazzar. At this point the narrative is interrupted by the interpolation. The next portion of the history which is certainly known to come from the hand of the Chronicler is the list, 5:7-42 (= Ezra 2:1-67), and where the narrative is resumed at the close of the list it appears that the returning exiles are already in Jerusalem. This is a surprising leap, especially for such a narrator as the Chronicler. We should certainly expect him to describe, with some detail, the starting of the expedition; to make express mention of the two leaders, Jeshua and Zerubbabel, whom he elsewhere makes so prominent; to tell of the provision made by the king—and afterward referred to—for the aid of the Jews and especially for the building of the temple; and so on.⁸ The probability at once suggests itself, that a part of the Chronicler's narrative is contained in the long sequel to the Story of the Three Youths, that is, in the section 4:43—5:6.

It would, of course, be the wish of the interpolator to use the original narrative as far as possible; and in this case that would be especially easy, since all the circumstances, and even the names (excepting only the name of the king), are identical. This probability becomes much stronger as soon as we observe the peculiar way in which the expansion of the Story has been effected. As was remarked above, it has been left absolutely untouched—saving the gloss of two words in 4:13—all the way from the beginning, 3:1, to 4:42, which is evidently the last verse of the original story which we have. It would have been an easy matter, and, we should say, most desirable, to add a bit of Jewish coloring, especially at the beginning, if only in order to make the connection more plausible. But the redactor took his task very easily, and apparently limited his own editorial additions to what was absolutely necessary. In view of this, it is surprising to find that the extra-canonical matter constituting the sequel to the Story occupies twenty-seven verses—about half the extent of the

⁸See my brief statement of the case in the *Journal of Biblical Literature*, 1897 pp. 168-70.

Story itself. And who is this who now begins to write at such length, and so methodically, what sounds like a piece of carefully composed history (vss. 47 ff.), and with such disproportionate interest in "the priests and the Levites" (vss. 52-56) and in "instruments of music" (4:63, 5:2)? These are the pet interests of the Chronicler himself; his peculiar property, in fact.

There is, indeed, plain evidence of composition in this long sequel, 4:43-5:6, showing that it consists of the work of the interpolator *plus* the work of the Chronicler. In the verse 5:6, especially, we can see how a harmonistic gloss has been added to the original text. The date, as it stands, is altogether out of place; and, indeed, it is difficult to imagine a reason for telling in any place the day of the month on which Zerubbabel made his successful speech. The words just preceding the date, "he who spoke wise words before Darius," are an obvious gloss, the last of the redactional patches by means of which the two documents were combined. This statement of year, month, and day was originally the Chronicler's date of the return from Babylon. Commentators have wondered why such a date was missing, in this history in which month and day of the month are never wanting, and on this occasion which overshadowed all others in importance. Verse 6 originally read: "in the second year of the reign of Cyrus, the king of Persia,⁹ in the month Nisan, on the first day¹⁰ of the month." The interpolator was, of course, obliged to alter "Cyrus" to "Darius" (as also in 5:2), and the insertion of his gloss necessitated a slight change in the wording of the sentence. Whoever examines 5:1-6 closely will see that it is written throughout in the characteristic phrases of the Chronicler, and this is true also of much of the latter part of chap. 4. The redactor's part is, indeed, as we were led to expect, a comparatively small one. Two brief passages, purely harmonistic, and easily recognized, are all that he has added, namely, vss. 43-46 (with the first clause of vs. 47) and vss. 57-61.¹¹

This conclusion, as to the Chronicler's authorship of 4:47-56 in particular, receives important confirmation from without. In

⁹ The phrase "king of Persia," מֶלֶךְ פֶּרְס, is a well-known mark of the Chronicler's hand.

¹⁰ In the Greek, τοῦ πρώτου μηνός, "the first month," is derived by some mistake from בִּאֲחֶר לַחֹדֶשׁ, as many have observed.

¹¹ These two patches, small as they are, contain some things of interest. Observe the statement regarding the Edomites, in vs. 45, and the very unusual phrase "king of heaven," in vss. 46 and 58.

Ezra 3:7 we are told how cedar-wood for the building of the temple was brought to the Jews from Lebanon "*according to the grant which they had from Cyrus, king of Persia;*" but the preceding narrative, in our canonical recension, contains no record of any such grant. But in this fragment of the Chronicler's history which survives in First Esdras, in 4:48, we have the edict to which reference was made: "He (Cyrus) wrote letters also unto . . . those that were in Lebanon, that they should bring cedar-wood from Lebanon to Jerusalem." Again in Ezra 3:1 (= I Esdr. 5:46 [47]) there is a statement of time which presupposes a definite date in the preceding narrative. Just after the long list of returning exiles, and the subjoined statement that the people arrived in Jerusalem and settled there and in the neighboring cities, the narrative continues: "And when the seventh month was come," etc. In our canonical Ezra there is no preceding date, to which this can be referred. The date in 1:1, "The first year of Cyrus, King of Persia," is not to be thought of, both because it is too indefinite and because the time would be far too short. And the Chronicler is particular about such matters as these; see, for example, Ezra 7:8, 9, and 8:31. But in the First Esdras recension, just before this list of returning exiles, we find the missing date, in 5:6 (the verse which has already been discussed; see above).

First Esdras, then contains a portion of the Chronicler's history which has been lost from our canonical book of Ezra. The original narrative passed directly on from 2:14 (= Ezra 1:11) to 4:47, which began thus: "[And Cyrus the king] wrote letters for him (i. e., for Sheshbazzar) unto all the administrators and governors," etc. Then, after the section 4:47-56, there followed immediately 4:62-5:6, and then 5:7 ff. (= Ezra 2:1 ff.). There is no reason to doubt that the history, as thus restored, is complete and in the very same form which its author gave it.

The interpolator, for his part, wrote 4:43-46, and the first clause of vs. 47 (altering the original slightly here), and vss. 57-61. He also changed "Cyrus" to "Darius" in 5:2 and 5:6, and inserted a gloss in the latter verse.¹² Whether the gloss in 4:13 is from him, or from a previous hand, may be questioned. It was he, finally, who transposed the Artaxerxes correspondence, Ezra 4:6-24, to the place where it now stands in First Esdras.

¹² The "Joachim" of this verse came from a misread יְחִיָּה, as I have shown elsewhere.

It is an interesting question, at what point the Aramaic text ended, and the Hebrew text began, in the composite narrative. It is, of course, certain that the Chronicler himself wrote all of this portion of his history in Hebrew (or what may be allowed to pass for Hebrew); and it is hardly less certain that the interpolator was as well acquainted with the one language as with the other. No one will question that the verses 4:43-46, at least, were written in Aramaic;¹³ and it may also be taken for granted that the passage 5:1-6 was allowed to stand in its original Hebrew. But in regard to the intermediate portion, 4:47-63, there is room for doubt, since it is conceivable that the interpolator should have written vss. 57-61 in Aramaic, and then have translated the Chronicler's Hebrew up to and just beyond that point, in order to conceal from sight the real place of the juncture. It is improbable, however, that he would have made himself this unnecessary labor. So far as we can judge, from the very few Jewish productions of this period that have survived, the combination of Hebrew and Aramaic in the same document was a common thing. It was possible, for instance, for the Chronicler to compose Ezra 6:16-18 in Aramaic, and then continue the same narrative in Hebrew in vss. 19 ff.—although he could not have had any reason for wishing to deceive his readers as to where the preceding document ended. Similarly, in Dan. 2:4 we see the change from the one language to the other taking place in the middle of a sentence, the narrative then going on as though nothing had happened. Obviously, such abrupt changes as these were not felt to be disturbing. So far as the Greek of this part of First Esdras is concerned, the last sure sign of an Aramaic original is the *τότε* of vs. 47. Beyond this point, the language seems to me everywhere to suggest Hebrew rather than Aramaic, though I have not been able to find any decisive proof. I therefore believe that the interpolator's Aramaic continued as far as the first words of the Chronicler's narrative, and that everything after this was Hebrew, including vss. 57-61. That is, vs. 47 began

¹³ Aside from the strong probability that this added patch would be written in the same language as the preceding narrative, we have the evidence of *τότε* in vs. 43, the position of the infinitive *ἐκπέμψαι* in vs. 44, and the *κύριε βασιλεῦ* (apparently מַלְכָּא מִרְיָא, as in Dan. 4:21) in vs. 46. The last-named verse, by the way, contains an evident mistranslation, the conjunction *ἵ* being rendered by *καί*, instead of by some word meaning, "since," "inasmuch as." The Aramaic was: *וְדָא דִּיהָ רַבִּיתָא (רַי) מִן לְתֵתָּהּ*, "since such munificence is thine." The Aramaic *רַבִּיתָא* used here exactly like *גְּדִילָה* in II Sam. 7:21, I Chron. 17:19, where also the Greek rendered by *μεγίστη*.

in Aramaic: "Then Darius the king arose, and kissed him;" and it was continued *in Hebrew*: "And he wrote letters for him unto all the administrators and governors," etc.

The result of this investigation has been, to restore a lost half-chapter to our "canonical" Old Testament—a thing which has never been done before, and presumably will never be done again—and to give the Story of the Three Youths its true place as an important specimen of old Aramaic literature. I hope to throw further light on the origin of this Story in a subsequent chapter.

IV. THE ORIGIN OF OUR TWO RECENSIONS

The Chronicler, probably not far from the middle of the third century B. C., but possibly later, wrote his Levitical History of Israel. Its contents, in their original order, were as follows: I and II Chronicles; Ezr. 1; *I Esdr.* 4:47–56; 4:62–5:6; Ezr. 2:1–8:36; *Neh.* 7:70–8:18; Ezr. 9:1–10:44; *Neh.* 9:1–10:40; *Neh.* 1:1–7:69; 11:1–13:31.

At the beginning of the last century B. C. this history was current only in a form which differed from the original form in two important particulars: (1) Three chapters originally belonging to the story of Ezra had been accidentally transposed, by a natural mistake,¹⁴ into the book of Nehemiah. (2) The Aramaic Story of the Three Youths had been interpolated. The interpolator added a few harmonistic verses at the end of the Story, and also *transposed the passage Ezra 4:6–24* to a place just before it.

Somewhat later, still another alteration found its way into numerous copies of the work. The fact that the account of *the reading of the Law* (*Neh.* 7:73–8:18), and that of *the sealing of the covenant* (*Neh.* 9:1–10:40), had originally belonged to the story of Ezra was not lost sight of among the Jews. Accordingly, someone, at some time in the last century B. C., made an attempt to restore the history to its true form by transposing these chapters to the place from which they were supposed to have come. That is, they were simply appended to the story of Ezra, being made to follow Ezra 10. It must be noted, however, that *not all* of the matter which had originally belonged to the story of Ezra was restored at this time. The three verses *Neh.* 7:70–72 were so securely lodged in their new surroundings (owing to the same considera-

¹⁴See my *Composition of Ezr.-Neh.*, p. 34.

tions which had caused their transfer thither) that they were no longer movable. The re-transferred section accordingly began with 7:73.

The result was (as we have the best of evidence) that *two editions* of the Chronicler's book, with its interpolated Story of the Youths, were current at the beginning of the Christian era. The two differed only at one point, namely, the section Neh. 7:73—10:40, containing the story of the Reading of the Law and the account of the Sealing of the Covenant. In the one edition (call it A) the position of this section was the same as in our massoretic Hebrew Bible; in the other edition (call it B) it had been appended to the Book of Ezra, of which it formed the close, Ezra 10:44 being continued by Neh. 7:73; and in neither edition were the two narratives which constitute this section in their original and proper context! To describe the two editions a little more fully:

A = I and II Chron.; history from Cyrus to the completion of the temple as in I Esdr.; stories of Ezra and Nehemiah as in our Hebrew Bible.

B = I and II Chron.; history from Cyrus to the completion of the temple as in I Esdr.; story of Ezra concluding with Neh. 7:73—10:40; story of Nehemiah as in our Hebrew Bible *minus* the section just mentioned.

One point in the description of Edition B requires special proof here, namely, the statement that not only Neh. 8, but also chaps. 9 and 10, were retransposed to the end of Ezra. That chap. 8 was thus transferred we know, of course, from First Esdras. Our only surviving text, however, breaks off at the beginning of vs. 13, in this chapter; so for an answer to the question, What came next? we must turn to other evidence. This is of two kinds:

1. *General probability*.—Chaps. 9 and 10 had long been connected with chap. 8, and must have been felt to be of one piece with it. Whoever had acumen enough to see that chap. 8 was out of place in the Book of Nehemiah must also have seen (as readers of the book in all ages have seen) that chaps. 9 and 10 belonged with equal certainty to the story of Ezra. The testimony of such verses as 9:1-3, 4 f. (cf. 8:4, 7); 10:28(!), 29,

30, could not be misunderstood.¹⁵ And with chap. 8 removed, the incongruity of chaps. 9 and 10 with their surroundings would be very much more obvious. Imagine 9:1 following directly upon 7:72!

2. *The evidence from Josephus.*—Josephus, who is the earliest writer (of those known to us) to excerpt the Chronicler's history, used Edition B. As his method is to give only such extracts as suit his purpose, and he frequently vaults over whole chapters and gives to others only a sentence or a clause, it is not always easy to follow him. The two chapters, Neh. 9 and 10, obviously contain hardly anything that he could use for his history; and, in fact, he makes no use of them at all, unless we find them alluded to in certain phrases at the end of his abridgment of Neh. 8. In telling the story of Ezra, when he comes to the account of the reading of the law he gives in concise form the contents of Neh. 8, to the very end of the chapter (*Antt.*, xi, 154–57). In finishing the account, he says that Ezra urged the people not to mourn, saying that it would be better for them at that time to keep the feast with joy, καὶ τὴν μετάνοιαν καὶ λύπην τὴν ἐπὶ τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν ἐξημαρτημένοις ἀσφάλειάν τε ἔξιν καὶ φυλακὴν τοῦ μηδὲν ὅμοιον συμπεσεῖν. And he then adds, that after the people had kept the feast for the eight days, ἀνεχώρησαν εἰς τὰ οἰκεία μετὰ ὕμνων τοῦ θεοῦ (cf. Neh. 9:5?) τῆς ἐπανορθώσεως τῶν περὶ τὸ πολίτευμα παρανομηθέντων "Εξδρα χάριν εἰδότες. Either one or both of these passages may well have been suggested by Neh. 9 and 10; but more than this can hardly be said. Josephus then passes on to the story of Nehemiah, which he gives in greatly abridged form. After narrating how the building of the wall was finished, he proceeds (xi, 180 f.): τὰ μὲν οὖν ἔθνη τὰ ἐν τῇ Συρίᾳ . . . ἐδυσφόρει (= Neh. 6:16—end). Νεεμίας δὲ τὴν πόλιν ὁρῶν ὀλιγανθρωπουμένην (= Neh. 7:4, καὶ ὁ λαὸς ὀλίγος ἐν αὐτῇ) τοὺς ἱερεῖς τε καὶ Λευῖτας παρεκάλεσεν τὴν χώραν ἐκλιπόντας μετελθεῖν εἰς τὴν πόλιν καὶ μένειν ἐν αὐτῇ. (Neh. 11:1, 10–23; 12:1–26) τὸν τε γεωργοῦντα λαὸν τὰς δεκάτας τῶν καρπῶν ἐκέλευσε φέρειν εἰς Ἱεροσόλυμα, ἵνα τρέφεσθαι διηνεκῶς ἔχοντες οἱ ἱερεῖς καὶ Λευῖται μὴ καταλείπωσι τὴν θρησκείαν (Neh. 12:44; 13:10–12).

It can hardly be doubted, in view of all this—and with nothing to point to the contrary conclusion—that the two chapters, Neh. 9 and 10, stood at the end of the book of Ezra in the B edition.

¹⁵ To say nothing of the καὶ εἶπεν Ἐξδρας with which 9:6 begins in the Greek version!

Both editions, A and B, must have continued in use for a considerable time. The extent to which Edition B was used may be judged from the fact that it was the one from which the old Greek version was made, as well as the one used by Josephus in writing his history of the Jews;¹⁶ while for a witness to the prestige of Edition A we have the fact that it was ultimately taken as the basis of the recension which alone was adopted for the "official" Hebrew Bible.

It deserves especially to be emphasized that the Story of the Three Youths was present in both of the current forms of the history. At the beginning of the Christian era, there was probably no version of the Chronicler's book in existence which did not contain this Story. Certain it is, at any rate, that those who made the recension now represented by our massoretic text knew of no such form already existing, but were obliged to resort to excision.

The trouble caused in the Jewish world by this Levitical History of Israel, in its two incongruous editions, could be imagined even if we had no direct proof of it. As time went on, and the lingering traditional knowledge of the Persian period dwindled and disappeared, the Chronicler's compilation stood out conspicuously as the one document dealing with the history of the Jews in this important time. It seems to have been little used at first, and when at last it became generally known it was looked upon with suspicion (witness its position in the Jewish canon, and its rejection from the Syriac Bible, to say nothing of other indications), but its ultimate recognition was inevitable. The final test came, of course, when the idea of a definite "canon" of divinely inspired scripture was first developed; namely, about the beginning of the second century A. D. The Jewish rabbis were obliged to meet squarely the question whether they should accept this book or reject it. On the one hand, it was the source, and the indispensable support, of certain theories which had come to be implicitly believed and cherished, especially in ecclesiastical circles; but, on the other hand, it was obviously an untrustworthy guide. Anyone could see that the Story of the Three Youths was incongruous with its surroundings, and it needed no unusual acumen to see that it was in fact an interpolation. Such naïve attempts to cut the knot as that of Josephus, who substitutes

¹⁶ And Josephus, as we know, was a writer who would have been careful to employ the *orthodox* recension.

"Cambyases" for the Artaxerxes of I Esdr. 2:15 ff., could only do more harm than good. And the case with the history of the two great leaders, Ezra and Nehemiah, was no better, for *two* versions, incompatible with each other, were in circulation. The situation was an intolerable one, and could be ended only in one way, namely, by a new recension.

A final revision was accordingly made, and was officially adopted. The Story of the Youths was cut out bodily from the book, and care was taken that it should never again appear in the Jewish sacred writings. But unfortunately, in the excision of the Story, *a part of the Chronicler's original narrative was cut out with it.* The cause of this accident is easy to see. The expanded Story, as edited by the interpolator, did not end with I Esdr. 4:63, but extended through the first six verses of chap. 5. The interpolation in vs. 6, supported by the occurrence of the name "Darius" both here and in vs. 2, left the revisers no alternative; the knife must cut between vss. 6 and 7. Upon the excision of the Story followed necessarily the restoration of the Artaxerxes correspondence to its proper place.

The choice between the two versions of the Ezra-Nehemiah story must have caused more difficulty. What led the Jewish revisers here to follow Edition A rather than Edition B can only be a matter of conjecture. Possibly some external evidence showing that the order of chapters in the former was older than that in the latter was still in existence. But it is perhaps more likely that what decided the matter was the presence, through interpolation, of Nehemiah's name in the three doubtful chapters (see Neh. 8:9 and 10:1, and compare the date in 1:1), an interpolation which easily (and almost inevitably) took place after these chapters had been accidentally transposed into the story of Nehemiah.

So much for the origin of our canonical Ezra. As for our First Esdras, it is, as has already been said, the one surviving fragment of the old Greek version of the Chronicler's history, a version which was simply a faithful rendering of Edition B, and was probably made in the latter part of the last century B. C. The accompanying diagram will serve to illustrate the history of the two recensions.

The extent of our First Esdras, it is hardly necessary to add, is due simply to accident. Probably all the manuscripts, Semitic

Chronicler's History. *Hebrew-Aramaic*.
(250 B. C., or later)

Two long passages transposed from Ezra to Nehemiah; the
first by accident, the second as a necessary result
(Neh. 7:70—8:18 and 9:1—10:40)

Story of the Three Youths
(I Esdr. 3:1—4:42).
Aramaic

(Redactional expansions [I Esdr. 4:43—47*a*; 57—61] and
alterations. Transposition of Ezra 4:6—24)

Edition A

Edition B (Neh. 7:73—10:40 trans-
posed to end of Ezra)

Excision of the Story; together with
a part of the original history,
I Esdr. 4:47*b*—56; 4:62—5:6.
(Beginning of second century A. D.)

Canonical Ezra-Nehemiah

Greek translation (before middle
of second century B. C.)

First Esdras

or Greek, which contained any other version than the official one were systematically destroyed. Just as the old Greek version of Daniel narrowly escaped the fate which befell its Semitic original, being saved only in a single Greek codex and a secondary version, so this portion of the condemned Esdras recension was rescued by a lucky chance. There was only one such fragment, and all of our "I Esdras" texts and translations go back to it. It probably consisted of a few quires plucked out of the middle of a codex. The first page of the rescued fragment began with II Chron. 35:1; and the last words on the last page were *καὶ ἐπισυνήχθησαν*, which in this version had been the first words of Neh. 8:13.

And it is certain, finally, that the manuscript from which this piece survived was Greek, not Semitic. There never existed a Hebrew-Aramaic fragment of the same extent as our First Esdras. Conclusive proof of this statement is found in the closing words, for in the Hebrew text Neh. 8:13 begins with *וביום השני*, not with the verb.

Whether accidentally rescued or deliberately excised, it is evident that this fragment was not altered nor edited in any way by those who first preserved it by itself. No attempt was made to give it a suitable beginning, nor even to complete the obviously unfinished sentence with which it ends.¹⁷ In every library of ancient manuscripts there are to be found similar fragments, consisting generally of a few quires surviving from codices of which the remainder has been lost;¹⁸ fragments almost always through accident, but sometimes also through selection. In the sense in which any one of these might be called a "book," First Esdras may be given that designation, but in no other sense.

¹⁷ Except in the Lagarde Greek recension, which here, as in some other places (compare what was said above regarding the text of 4:39) has been deliberately "revised."

¹⁸ Compare, for example, the accidental loss of the first part of the Peshitto version of Tobit, which has totally disappeared.

III

THE STORY OF THE THREE YOUTHS

(I Esdras 3:1—4:42)

I. ORIGIN OF THE STORY

Among the most interesting surviving specimens of old Semitic literature must be counted the story of the three young guardsmen at the court of King Darius, and their contest of wits in the royal audience hall. As has already been shown (see above, pp. 18-30), this narrative was originally written in the Aramaic language, and was interpolated in the Chronicler's history of Israel by an unknown hand, probably near the beginning of the second century B. C. The main questions as to its origin, date, and primitive form, and the class of literature to which it belongs, remain to be answered. It is now generally believed that this "story" was a Jewish composition, a "contribution to the legendary history of the Captivity and Return" (Swete, *Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek*, p. 266); and the only remark which it ordinarily calls forth is the verdict that it "is unhistorical." I shall try to show in the following pages that it was originally a separate composition, a bit of popular wisdom-literature complete in itself, and in its first estate having nothing to do with the history of the Jews; that it was composed in Palestine, probably soon after 300 B. C.; that it was incorporated entire in the Chronicler's history, and has been preserved in what is substantially its original form.

The interpolator, as I have shown (see pp. 25-27), gave the story, in the main, as he found it, without attempting to work it over, or indeed to make any alteration whatever beyond what was absolutely necessary. The beginning, obviously, was left untouched. Up to the end of 4:42, moreover, there is not a clause, nor even a word, that seems to be secondary or editorial, excepting of course the manifest gloss in 4:13. It was only at the end, where the story required to be adapted to a definite place in Jewish history, that redactional patches were necessary, and were made. The interpolator himself did this harmonistic work; and one